Modern Art & Ideas

Today's goal • 3/3 items

Module 1
Introduction to Modern Art & Ideas

Module 2
Places & Spaces

Module 3
Art & Identity

Module 4
Transforming Everyday Objects

Introduction to Transforming Everyday Objects

- Welcome to Module 4
  Reading • 10 min
- Transforming Everyday Objects
  Video • 4 min

Transforming How Objects Look

- How do artists draw from their surroundings?
  Reading • 20 min
- Ruth Asawa. Untitled (BMC. 145, BMC Laundry Stamp). c. 1948-49
  Video • 1 min
- Practical Scenario
  Real-world application • 5 min
- Noah Purifoy. Unknown. 1967
  Video • 2 min

Transforming What Objects Mean

- How do artists alter the meaning of objects?
  Reading • 10 min
- Alfonso Ossorio. Empty Chair or The Last Colonial. 1969
  Video • 2 min
- Practical Scenario
  Real-world application • 5 min
- Diamond Stingily. Entryways. 2021
  Video • 1 min

Transforming What Objects Do

- **How do designers problem-solve?**
  Reading • 10 min
- Clara Porset. Butaque Chair. 1957
  Video • 2 min
- Tomás Gabzdil Libertiny. The Honeycomb Vase "Made by Bees" (Prototype). 2006
  Video • 2 min

Review & Reflect

- Optional Readings & Resources
  Reading • 10 min
- Assessment:Transforming Everyday Objects
  Dialogue • 15 min
- Optional Prompts for Discussion & Reflection
  Reading • 10 min

Module 5
Module 5: Art & Society

Module 6
Course Conclusion

How do designers problem-solve?

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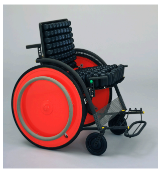
Décolletage Plastique Design Team. Bic Cristal Ballpoint pen. 1950. Polystyrene, polypropylene, and tungsten carbide, 5 7/8 x 1/2" (14.9 x 1.3 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Gift of the manufacturer. © 2016 Société Bic, France

While it may be easy to take for granted the availability of a seemingly endless array of ballpoint pens today, it took ingenuity to think of such a thing in the first place. The first ballpoint pen was invented in 1938 by a Hungarian journalist who sought a better writing implement, through which ink could flow more regularly.

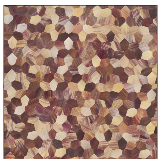
Twelve years later, after a year of work by a team of designers at the French company Bic, the Bic Cristal® ballpoint pen was introduced to the marketplace. This was the company's first ballpoint pen. Its co-founder, Marcel Bich, had invested in technology to allow his designers to craft the finest, most precise pen possible, which not only wrote well but also was comfortable to hold. After its initial success in France, the company took the pen to the American market in 1959, promoting it with the advertising pitch: "writes first time, every time."



Kazuo Kawasaki. Carna Folding Wheelchair. 1989. Titanium, rubber, and aluminum honeycomb, 33 x 22 x 35 1/4" (83.8 x 55.9 x 89.5 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Gift of the designer

When he was 28, industrial designer Kazuo Kawasaki was in a car accident that left him paralyzed. Dissatisfied with existing wheelchair options, he sought to create one that would be light, collapsible, comfortable—and as cool as the newest pair of sneakers. What he came up with was a titanium frame touched with spots of canary yellow, bright red aluminum wheels with a honeycomb core, and a rubber seat covered in fingerlike projections.

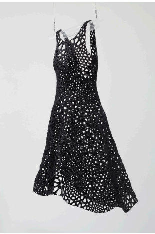
Stylish and functional, the wheelchair weighs a mere 13 pounds and comes with additional parts that allow users to customize it. Its namesake is the Roman goddess Carna, protector of entrances, exits, and the body's vital organs. As Kawasaki maintains: "…designers need to make designs that are kind and caring."



Fernando Laposse. *Totomoxtle*. 2017. Corn husks and glue on MDF board. Approx.: 47 1/4 × 47 1/4 × 1 1/2" (120 × 120 × 3.8 cm). Committee on Architecture and Design Funds

"Totomoxtle" is a word that describes corn husks in several Indigenous languages in Mexico. Designer Fernando Laposse takes the husks at the end of the corn's life cycle, once they're fully dry then he works the material into a thin sheet like a wood veneer: flattening it, ironing it, and gluing it, and laminating it onto paper. Laposse and his team have a variety of methods to cut it into shapes and to reassemble it to create continuous surfaces for furniture or a wall covering.

The project began when Laposse embarked on a mission to reintroduce native seeds to Tonahuixtla and bring traditional agricultural practices back into practice. Corn is found in more than 80% of recipes in Mexico and is not only a crucial source of nutrition but also a keystone of the nation's culture. Laposse observes, "*Totomoxtle* is also a social project. It's not about only creating the material, but also about creating a self-sustaining system that looks at small-scale farming economies, Indigenous rights, land rights, and erosion. It really tries to shine a light on diversity."



Jessica Rosenkrantz, Jesse Louis-Rosenberg. Kinematics Dress. 2013. Laser-sintered nylon, 44 x 37 x 2" (111.8 x 94 x 5.1 cm) irreg. The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Gift of the Committee on Architecture and Design Funds and Shapeways

Designers and co-founders of Nervous System studio Jessica Rosenkrantz and Jesse Louis-Rosenberg merged nature and technology to make their line of Kinematics garments. This 3-D printed nylon dress is composed of thousands of individual triangular panels connected by hinges. Each dress is unique—shaped to a 3-D scan of the wearer's body—and details including its length, patterning, and silhouette can be customized. After adjustments are made, the dress is printed in its entirety and ready for wear.

For Rosenkrantz and Louis-Rosenberg, this process, with its lack of a fixed outcome, mimics the adaptive processes of development in nature and provides an alternative to (and perhaps eventually a replacement for) the uniformity of mass manufacturing. "Instead of creating…millions of items that are all the same, we're creating something that maybe only just appeals to one person, but they can get that exact one thing that they want," explains Louis-Rosenberg.

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